

# THE KESTREL OF LANTERN- FALL

*Fourth Wall Gaming*

## CHAPTER ONE — THE LAST SUPPER



Sefa Rocksquill killed the drake at dusk over the fourth ring.

She was flying the lamp-patrol when it came in low out of the east, riding the dead air, and it did not see her. She folded her wings and dropped on it with the wingspear couched. The point went through the root of its left wing. The drake screamed and tore loose and fell twelve metres onto the lamp-ring scaffold and broke its other wing on the bone.

She came down after it. Her hatchet rang off its skull and did nothing. She set her boot on its neck and pulled at the spear and the spear would not come. She pulled again. It would not come.

Then the drake got her left arm in its jaws and held. It threw its weight over the rim and tried to take her down into the deep sky by the arm. She braced and wrenched and the grip broke. The wing-skin tore off the spear-point and the drake fell away alone and got small and was gone. She kept the spear.

The lamp-tenders had watched it and they called for Wardens. Two came. The medic cut her harness off and dressed the arm.

“Sky-drakes are windlane hunters,” he said. “A drake doesn’t choose its ground. It goes where the wind packs the prey.” He pressed the dressing flat. “This one was thin under the hide. Third eastern stray this month. It wasn’t hunting here because here is good. It was

hunting here because the east is empty. Starving things come to the light.” He looked at her. “You did it a kindness.”

A lamp-tender on the scaffold said, “The east haze used to sing with skimmers at dusk. Been quiet since the thaw.”

Sefa flew in to make her report with her arm splinted to her ribs.

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Esk Veil-Torn drafted fliers, not invalids.

She stood at the survey table with the eastern charts pinned and the dead-air flags clustered along the old lane. She offered three days’ rest or the dawn launch.

“Sooner is better,” Sefa said. “Wouldn’t you say, commander?”

At next light she met Kithrel of the Moults on the eastern launch ledge. Kithrel was the fastest survey-flier on the muster. She had come out of Greywake alive and she wore eleven lane-tokens braided into her primaries and did not talk about them.

“Out to the Veyl shallows along the old east lane,” Kithrel said. “I read the air, you watch the sky. When I say we turn, we turn. The edge doesn’t negotiate.”

“I’ll try to keep up,” Sefa said.

They flew east and the wind died around them by degrees. At fifteen kilometres Sefa saw pale shapes on a skim-reef in the haze and could not make them out. Kithrel looked.

“Nine years on this lane,” she said. “That is none of them.”

They came in high and offset. At four hundred metres Kithrel read the aneroid.

“Zero,” she said. “Not low. Zero. There is no breath in this air at all. The still zone isn’t out at the shallows. It’s here.”

On the reef stood nine figures in wax-bleached robes. They faced east and sang low and together and they did not turn. Among them

drifted pale bells the size of a crouching man. The bells went from singer to singer and settled over the faces and drank.

The pair pulled back to a reef-knuckle a kilometre and a half west of the zero line and set a picket behind the bone-spine with the light at their backs. They watched. The Choir went from nine voices to seven. The bells went from seven to nine.

“Head home,” Sefa said. “We don’t need to count them to know what’s going to happen. Next we find the ones who sent these fools out here to die. Fly quiet and fly safe.”

They went west, low and quiet.

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The threads ran down into the under-city.

A foreman at Orrim’s Pale-Vats had run night-shift white work in the spring. Nine bodies’ worth of wax, taken from a soft-spoken hooded Vael who paid over the odds and did not haggle. The nine bundles went down into the condemned bone-galleries under the windlane approach. The beggars in the under-stair knew of a supper held there every ninth night. The next was the next night.

The foreman’s name was Bele Tarrow. Sefa went to him without the writ.

She found him at the Tallow Cup between the first bell and the second. He was Roak, big and gone soft in the shoulders, grey at the crest. He sat with his back to the wall and watched the door. He had a child’s tally-bead bracelet on his wrist and he touched it without knowing it.

She sat down on the stool beside him. She had the charter in her pocket and she left it there.

“You heard about the drake this week?” she said.

“You’re the Rocksquill,” he said. “The Kestrel.”

She looked at him. He was frightened and he was not paid, and he was grieving for something he had not lost yet.

“Is everyone okay?” she said. “Anything I could help you with, Bele Tarrow?”

He told her then. His daughter Derra had gone quiet at Winterend. A vat-clerk on his own floor, the best tally-hand in the works. First no words, then no sound, then the air going soft around her. A soft-spoken Vael with clean hands found him after his shift.

“He said it just like this,” Tarrow said. “The silence is not a sickness, foreman. It is an arrival. She will be honored among us, and you may pay her keeping like any loving father pays a dowry.”

So he paid. Bread and water-jugs and mooring rope, every ninth night, off his own tally, left at the third side-mouth past the under-stair. He had seen her once, at Solstice, let to stand at a curtain. She was straightening the mats.

“She looked kept,” he said. “That’s all I can say. Kept.”

Nine days ago the asking changed. Rope in quantity. And lamp-oil. Four casks, and four more the next night.

“They sit in the dark down there,” Tarrow said. “They love the dark. So what does a congregation that doesn’t light lamps want with that much oil?”

“Those people who say they’re tending people with the stillness,” Sefa said. “They’re tending the stillness itself.”

“I know. I knew when they asked for the rope. You don’t need rope to tend the sick.”

He said the soft man gave the orders, and a woman with a cantor’s lilt and a big quiet one did what he said. Three ninth-nights back the soft man had worn a new pin. Small worked bone, the shape of a closed hand. Featherwright craft. The guild oath was “no one falls.”

He went to his shift at the second bell. At the door he turned.

“My girl, Warden,” he said. “Whatever you’re doing down there. My girl.”

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Esk heard all of it and named it. They were not worshipping under her spire. They were housing the Hushed and the bells together in one room, forty metres under her launch ledge, and feeding it. She gave the orders. Watch the supper. Do not raid it.

“I want the client,” she said. “Bring me a face.”

She took a falchion from the chart-room rack and put it in Sefa’s hand. “Bring it back with a story or don’t bother bringing it back.” Sefa took it and drew a throwing hatchet and racked her wingspear as too long for the bone halls.

They went down before the next night’s supper.

They split at the gallery mouth. Kithrel stayed there with three flares and Esk’s runner. Sefa went up into the vault of the supper-room on the north scaffold and folded onto the perch in the dark and watched.

The keeper came first. A Vael woman, flat-feathered, a burn-scar on one thumb. She lit the tallow down the half-circle of mats. Then six families came in and took the mats. Then the Hushed, seven of them, led in, the flames leaning as they passed. Among them was a small woman with ink on her fingers. Derra Tarrow.

Then three came through the felt arch. A big silent Ossuin. A woman in grey with an ash-censer. And between them a soft-faced Vael with clean hands and a closed-hand pin at his collar. Vesh.

He lifted his hands to the mats.

“Friends. You’ve fed them faithfully, and they’ve grown. Tonight they’re ready to give back what the world gave them — and you’ll have your beloveds returned to the air they came from. All of you. Tonight is the last supper. After this, no one need pay again.”

The big man put his hand on an oil-cask.

Sefa threw the hatchet from the perch. It went into the big man’s wrist and the oil stopped and every face in the room turned up.

Vesh had a striker in his hand over the spilled oil. He did not crank it.

“A Warden. Of course,” he said. “Come down, feather. You don’t want to be up there when this room goes to sleep. There’s no flying in dead air. And there’s no flying at all once I turn my wrist.”

“You’re surrounded, surgeon,” Sefa said. “The whole draft’s in these galleries.”

“No,” he said. “There are no other wings. I’d have heard them. This air carries a lie better than it carries a flock.”

But the families had heard her name the casks. The grey-crested Lanhawk man stood up off his mat. “Vesh. He said it was a blessing. He said our daughter would only—”

Vesh sent the big man to the arch and kept the striker.

“To the flares!” Sefa shouted. “Go! The wing’s at the door!”

The families broke for the mouth. Kithrel’s flare went up red and she called them out.

Sefa dropped off the perch. Nine metres, straight down, the falchion out front. The dead air took the dive and the falchion opened on nothing and Vesh leaned aside. She wrenched it back and the blade came down through the root of his left wing and took the wing off. He fell. The striker turned in his hand on the way down and the oil caught.

The fire ran out in two lines. One to the mats. One to the casks. The Hushed pulled back from the light.

She took up Vesh to carry him out. Then the first cask began to sing. She rammed his body into the cask and went the other way, for the girl. The cask burst. It threw her and the fire caught her left wing.

She came down at Derra’s feet. The fire on her wing went small. The dead air around the girl starved it. Her own breath went thin in her chest.

She could not fly. She picked up the girl and held her breath and ran for the mouth. Fifteen metres. She went down five metres short.

She looped the rescue-line around Derra and shoved her toward Kithrel.

“Got her — I’ve got her!”

The hush went out with the girl and the fire came back. Sefa went down into the dark. Kithrel dropped the line and came in for her and dragged her out as a cask blew.

She woke on the cold floor of the gallery. The air was good. Kithrel had two fists in her harness.

“There she is,” Kithrel said. “There she is, you stubborn squill. I went in for you. Cask went off behind us. You owe me a drink.”

The families were out. Derra stood among them. The supper burned behind the arch with Vesh in it.

Sefa sat up and looked at her wing. The feathers were burned to black quills. The membrane was stiff and it hung wrong.

She looked at it for a while. Then she looked at Kithrel.

“Fuck,” she said.

“Yeah,” Kithrel said. “That about covers it.”

“I asked you to tell me when I got to do something satisfying.” She looked at the fire. “This wasn’t it.”

“Six families walked out,” Kithrel said. “The girl’s standing right there.”

“Let’s go home, Kith.”

“Yeah.” Kithrel got a hand under her bad side and took the weight. “Let’s go home.”